FREE GUIDE

THE

Think Richer™

FRAMEWORK

$0 to $100K

Your step-by-step roadmap to your first $100K and what to do once you get there.

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MONEY PSYCHOLOGY | LIFESTYLE FINANCE | FUTURE OF MONEY

INTRODUCTION

Why Most Women Never Hit $100K

It's not just about the math.

Getting to your first $100K is less about knowing the 'right' investment and more about building the right system -- and understanding the psychology that works against you. Research shows that behavioral biases like present bias, loss aversion, and lifestyle inflation derail people long before a bad investment ever does. Most people don't fail because they didn't try. They fail because they were never taught to outsmart their own brain.

This framework gives you the stages, the decisions, and the mindset shifts to move from $0 to $100K. Think of each stage as a level you unlock -- and your mind as the main character you have to coach the entire way.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Work through each stage in order -- don't skip ahead. Each stage includes:

Stage Goal -- what you're trying to achieve

The Steps -- what to actually do, in sequence

Brain Check -- the cognitive bias trying to stop you, and exactly how to beat it

The $0 to $100K Journey at a Glance

STAGE 1 Foundation > **STAGE 2** Kill Debt > **STAGE 3** Invest > **STAGE 4** Build > **$100K** Unlocked

The numbers are learnable. The mindset is the work.

STAGE 1

Build Your Foundation

Before you invest a dollar, protect yourself.

STAGE GOAL

Establish a starter emergency fund of $1,000, create a working budget, and eliminate financial chaos so you can think clearly about money. Clarity precedes action.

Step-by-Step

1. Track Every Dollar for 30 Days

You cannot fix what you cannot see. Use any consistent method -- a spreadsheet, a notebook, any tracking system. The tool is irrelevant. The awareness is everything. Most people are shocked by what they find.

2. Build a Zero-Based Budget

Assign every dollar a job: income minus all expenses = $0. Not because you're broke -- because you're intentional. Every unassigned dollar quietly disappears. This is the single most powerful budget framework in existence.

3. Save $1,000 Emergency Fund First

Park it somewhere separate from your checking account. This is your financial seatbelt. Without it, every unexpected expense becomes debt. With it, you stay on course.

4. List Every Single Debt

Write out every debt: the balance, the interest rate, the minimum payment. Most people avoid this because awareness feels painful. Do it anyway. The psychological weight of the unknown is always heavier than the truth.

5. Automate Your Minimum Payments

Set up autopay on every debt. This protects your credit score while you build momentum. Automation removes willpower from the equation -- and willpower is a finite, depletable resource.

6. Open a High-Yield Savings Account

A standard savings account earning near-zero erodes your money against inflation. A high-yield account earns meaningfully more with zero additional risk. One setup, passive benefit, forever.

BRAIN CHECK

Present Bias -- Why You'll Want to Skip Stage 1

Your brain is hardwired to prefer a smaller reward now over a larger reward later -- psychologists call this present bias (Thaler & Sunstein, 2008). It's why budgeting feels painful: you're giving up NOW for LATER, and your brain codes that as a loss. The fix is to stop relying on future-you's motivation and automate instead. Set up your savings transfer the day you get paid. What you never see, you never spend. Systems beat willpower every single time.

STAGE 2

Kill High-Interest Debt

Debt is the single biggest drag on wealth-building.

STAGE GOAL

Eliminate all high-interest debt -- anything above 6-7% interest. Credit card debt at 20%+ APR is a guaranteed negative investment. Every dollar you send here earns you a risk-free return.

Choose Your Payoff Strategy

Debt Avalanche

Pay minimums on all debts. Every extra dollar goes to the highest-interest debt first.

+ Mathematically optimal -- saves the most in interest over the life of your debt

+ Best for the person who is motivated by data and numbers

- Progress feels slower because early wins don't come as quickly

Recommended by most CFP®s for high-rate debt payoff

Debt Snowball

Pay minimums on all debts. Every extra dollar goes to the smallest balance first.

+ Fast wins trigger dopamine -- which fuels motivation to keep going

+ Better for people who need visible momentum to stay consistent

- Costs more in total interest paid over time

Research shows snowball users stay more consistent long-term

The Interest Rate Decision Guide

Interest Rate	What To Do	Why
20%+ (Credit Cards)	Pay off immediately -- before any extra investing	No investment reliably returns 20%+. Paying this off IS a guaranteed return.
8-19% (Personal / Private Loans)	Aggressively pay before major investing	High drag on net worth. The math does not favor investing first here.
5-7% (Federal Student Loans, Auto)	Balance: invest + pay down simultaneously	Historical market returns may outpace this. Do both at the same time.
Under 5% (Mortgage, Low-Rate Loans)	Minimum payments -- prioritize investing	Inflation and long-term returns historically exceed this rate.

BRAIN CHECK

Loss Aversion -- Why Paying Debt Feels Worse Than Gaining

Nobel Prize winner Daniel Kahneman found that losses feel 2x more painful than equivalent gains feel good (Prospect Theory, 1979). Sending $500 to your credit card feels worse than receiving a $500 raise -- your brain codes it as a loss. Reframe it: paying off 20% APR debt is a guaranteed 20% return. No investment reliably beats that. Every dollar you send is an investment in your own financial freedom.

STAGE 3

Start Investing -- The Right Order

Where you invest matters more than what you invest in.

STAGE GOAL

The sequence matters as much as the amount. Using accounts in the wrong order can cost you tens of thousands in unnecessary taxes -- and the right order depends on your timeline and goals.

The Investment Priority Order -- Follow This Sequence

#	Account / Action	2026 Limit	Why This Order
1	401(k) -- up to the employer match	Varies by employer	Instant 50-100% return on matched dollars. Free money. Always do this first.
2	Emergency Fund (High-Yield Savings)	N/A	3-6 months of expenses. The financial foundation everything else rests on.
3	Roth IRA (if income-eligible)	$7,500 / $8,600 if 50+	Tax-free growth forever. Contributions (not gains) accessible penalty-free anytime.
4	HSA (if eligible for an HDHP)	$4,400 individual / $8,750 family	Triple tax advantage: pre-tax in, tax-free growth, tax-free out for medical -- beats 401(k).
5	401(k) -- beyond the employer match	$24,500 total	Reduces taxable income. If retiring before 59.5, consider brokerage here instead.*
6	Taxable Brokerage Account	No limit	No age restrictions on withdrawals. Essential for early retirement or non-retirement goals.

**If retiring before 59.5 or saving for non-retirement goals, prioritize brokerage over fully maxing 401(k) -- no early withdrawal penalty.*

Source: IRS.gov | Limits are 2026 figures. Verify at IRS.gov each year as limits adjust annually.

Note: Your employer may offer a Roth 401(k) -- contributions are after-tax but growth and withdrawals are tax-free. Check your plan.

Note: A Traditional IRA may be used in place of a Roth IRA. Deductibility depends on income and workplace plan coverage -- see IRS.gov.

Roth IRA Eligibility -- 2026 Income Limits

Filing Status	Full Contribution	Phase-Out Range	No Contribution Above
Single / Head of Household	$7,500 ($8,600 if 50+)	$153,000 MAGI	$168,000 MAGI
Married Filing Jointly	$7,500 ($8,600 if 50+)	$242,000 MAGI	$252,000 MAGI
Married Filing Separately	See IRS (very limited)	$0 MAGI	$10,000 MAGI

Source: IRS.gov (IRS Notice 2025-67) | MAGI = Modified Adjusted Gross Income | Verify at IRS.gov annually.

BRAIN CHECK

The Disposition Effect -- Selling Winners, Keeping Losers

Research by Terrance Odean found that investors sell winning positions 1.5x more often than losing ones -- and those sold winners outperformed the retained losers by 3.4% per year afterward (1998). Your brain codes a paper loss as unbearable and a paper gain as something to lock in. The fix: automate contributions to low-cost index funds and set a rule not to check your account more than monthly. Consistency and boredom are the most underrated wealth-building strategies.

STAGE 4

Build to $100K

Income expansion, lifestyle discipline, and staying the course.

STAGE GOAL

Push your savings rate higher, grow your income, and protect your growing net worth from lifestyle inflation and the behavioral traps that stop most people right when momentum builds.

The Savings Rate Reality Check

Savings Rate	Approx. Years to $100K*	What It Takes Psychologically
5% (national avg)	25-30 years	Autopilot living. Present bias wins. Dangerous complacency.
10%	15-18 years	Aware and trying. Saver identity is beginning to form.
20%	8-10 years	Intentional wealth-builder. Identity is dominant. Real momentum.
30%+	5-7 years	High agency. Requires income growth + redesigning lifestyle defaults.

**Assumes $50K starting income, 7% avg annual return, inflation-adjusted estimates.*

Two Levers: Income & Expenses

Grow Income

+ Negotiate your salary -- research shows a single negotiation adds an avg of $5K-$7K annually

+ Build a side income: freelancing, consulting, content creation, teaching what you know

+ Invest in certifications or skills commanding higher market value

+ The raise rule: save at least 50% of every income increase before it reaches your lifestyle

Control Expenses

- The Big 3: housing, transport, food drive 80% of most budgets -- optimize these categories first

- Audit recurring charges quarterly -- the avg person has multiple forgotten subscriptions

- 24-hour rule on any non-essential purchase over $50 -- eliminates most emotional spending

- Design your environment to reduce temptation: add friction to spending, remove it from saving

BRAIN CHECK

Lifestyle Inflation -- The Silent Wealth Killer

Hedonic adaptation is the psychological tendency to return to a baseline level of happiness after a positive life change -- like a raise. Income rises, lifestyle rises to match it, and the financial gap stays the same. Research shows high earners can still live paycheck to paycheck because of this pattern. The antidote is the raise rule: every income increase triggers an automatic savings increase before the new income hits your spending account. What you automate, you do. What you leave to willpower, you eventually spend.

You Hit $100K. Now What?

Use this checklist to level up from $100K toward true financial freedom.

Practical + Behavioral -- because both matter.

PRACTICAL FINANCIAL CHECKLIST

- [ ] **Rebalance your portfolio once a year**
  Target 80-100% stocks if 10+ years to retirement. Drift silently erodes your allocation.
- [ ] **Review all insurance coverage annually**
  Life, disability, umbrella -- higher net worth creates new exposure. Know what you have.
- [ ] **Create or update your will + beneficiaries**
  Review after every major life event: marriage, children, divorce.
- [ ] **Know your effective vs. marginal tax rate**
  Most people know neither. This unlocks legitimate tax reduction strategies.
- [ ] **Max HSA every year if eligible**
  Triple tax advantage: pre-tax in, tax-free growth, tax-free out for qualified medical.
- [ ] **Open a taxable brokerage account**
  Only after maxing all tax-advantaged accounts. No contribution limits.
- [ ] **Keep a 6-month emergency fund always**
  Separate from investments. Liquid. Earning a competitive interest rate.
- [ ] **Meet with a fee-only CFP® at least once**
  Flat fee, not % of assets. Tax savings often pay for the consultation.

BEHAVIORAL FINANCE CHECKLIST

- [ ] **Stop checking your portfolio daily**
  DALBAR research: daily checkers make 3x more emotional trades and earn less as a result.
- [ ] **Set a purposeful spending plan, not restrictions**
  Intentional luxury beats impulse purchases. Align where money goes with what you value.
- [ ] **Audit your money beliefs from childhood**
  Scarcity mindset can sabotage wealth-building even after you have it.
- [ ] **Avoid the arrival fallacy**
  'When I hit $100K I'll finally feel okay' -- fulfillment is not a net worth number.
- [ ] **Automate all savings and investments**
  Remove willpower entirely. Let systems do the behavioral heavy lifting.
- [ ] **Celebrate intentionally -- then reinvest**
  Acknowledge the win. Plan exactly what you do with the next dollar. Both matter.
- [ ] **Define your 'enough' number**
  Financial independence looks different for everyone. Define yours, or you'll never arrive.
- [ ] **Review this framework every 6 months**
  Your situation evolves. Your strategy, savings rate, and goals should too.

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